Living by Faith, Not by Sight

Practical Christian Living — Lesson 13 of 16

"For we walk by faith, not by sight." — 2 Corinthians 5:7 (KJV)

Lesson purpose

To understand what Paul means by walking by faith, recognize that fear does not cancel genuine faith, and learn to depend on God's Word and the Holy Spirit in daily obedience.

1. Observation — What does Scripture say?

In 2 Corinthians 5:1–10, Paul contrasts our present earthly condition with the future hope believers have in Christ. His confidence rests on what God has promised, even though that future is not yet visible.

"We walk": This describes an ongoing manner of living. **"By faith":** Our confidence rests in God and His promises. **"Not by sight":** What we presently see is not the final measure of what God has promised.

2. Interpretation — What does it mean?

Walking by faith means living with confidence in God's character and revealed promises, particularly our hope in Christ, while recognizing the limits of present sight and understanding.

It does **not** mean ignoring evidence, refusing wise counsel, or assuming that every personal desire is a promise from God. Faith is rooted in who God is and what He has actually said.

Supporting Scriptures: Hebrews 11:1; Romans 10:17; James 2:17.

3. Faith and our five senses

We naturally depend upon what we can see, hear, touch, taste, and smell. These are valuable gifts, but they cannot fully reveal spiritual realities or the future God has promised.

Fear, uncertainty, and strong feelings may remain even in genuine believers. We need not deny these experiences; rather, we learn not to make them the final authority over God's Word.

Examples: David confessed his fear and chose to trust God (Psalm 56:3); a father cried, "Lord, I believe; help thou mine unbelief" (Mark 9:24, KJV).

4. Faith moves toward obedience

Abraham went when God called, though he did not know his destination (Genesis 12:1–4; Hebrews 11:8). His trust was expressed through action.

Obedience does not earn salvation. Rather, a living faith increasingly shapes the decisions and conduct of those who belong to Christ (James 2:17). Ask: What has God clearly commanded me to do today?

5. The Holy Spirit strengthens believers

God does not ask believers to overcome fear through willpower alone. He works within His people, forming godly desires and empowering faithful action (Philippians 2:13; Galatians 5:16).

Second Timothy 1:7 reminds Timothy that God has not given a spirit of fearfulness, but of power, love, and a sound mind. This is encouragement to act faithfully, not a promise that Christians will never feel afraid.

6. Test guidance by God’s Word

The Holy Spirit does not contradict the truth God has revealed in Scripture. Jesus called Him the Spirit of truth (John 16:13–14), and believers are instructed to test spiritual claims (1 John 4:1).

Ask three questions: (1) Does this agree with Scripture in context? (2) Am I seeking wisdom in prayer rather than treating a feeling as unquestionable revelation? (3) Does the direction encourage obedience to Christ and the fruit of the Spirit (Galatians 5:22–23)?

7. Practical Christian living — this week

Read: Study 2 Corinthians 5:1–10 before focusing on verse 7. **Pray:** Name one situation that creates fear or uncertainty. **Compare:** Write what you feel beside what Scripture actually teaches. **Respond:** Choose one concrete act of obedience that is consistent with God's Word. **Reflect:** At week's end, consider how God strengthened your trust, whether or not the circumstances changed.

Reflection and discussion questions

1. What is Paul's main concern in 2 Corinthians 5:1–10, and how does verse 7 fit?

2. How is trust in God different from merely hoping for a favorable outcome?

3. Can faith and fear exist together? What do Psalm 56:3 and Mark 9:24 show?

4. How does the Holy Spirit enable obedience, and how do we test a supposed spiritual leading?

5. Identify one area of life where you need to trust God and obey what Scripture teaches.

Closing prayer

Heavenly Father, teach us to walk by faith and not by sight. When fear or uncertainty rises, help us remember Your faithfulness and the promises You have given in Christ. Through Your Holy Spirit, strengthen us to understand and obey Your Word. Guard us from relying only on our feelings or our own wisdom. May our lives honor Jesus Christ. In His name, amen.